Equivalence Relations and Apartness Relations

The Clowder Project Authors

June 21, 2025

01R3 This chapter contains some material about reflexive, symmetric, transitive, equivalence, and apartness relations.

Contents

1 Reflexive Relations **2**
1.1 Foundations 2
1.2 The Reflexive Closure of a Relation 2

2 Symmetric Relations **4**
2.1 Foundations 4
2.2 The Symmetric Closure of a Relation 5

3 Transitive Relations **7**
3.1 Foundations 7
3.2 The Transitive Closure of a Relation 8

4 Equivalence Relations **10**
4.1 Foundations 10
4.2 The Equivalence Closure of a Relation 11

5 Quotients by Equivalence Relations **12**
5.1 Equivalence Classes 12
5.2 Quotients of Sets by Equivalence Relations 12

A Other Chapters **18**

1 Reflexive Relations

1.1 Foundations

Let A be a set.

01R6 **Definition 1.1.1.1.** A **reflexive relation** is equivalently:[1]

- An $\mathbb{E}_0$-monoid in $(\mathrm{N}_\bullet(\mathbf{Rel}(A, A)), \chi_A)$.
- A pointed object in $(\mathbf{Rel}(A, A), \chi_A)$.

01R7 **Remark 1.1.1.2.** In detail, a relation R on A is **reflexive** if we have an inclusion

$$\eta_R \colon \chi_A \subset R$$

of relations in $\mathbf{Rel}(A, A)$, i.e. if, for each $a \in A$, we have $a \sim_R a$.

01R8 **Definition 1.1.1.3.** Let A be a set.

01R9 1. The **set of reflexive relations on** A is the subset $\mathrm{Rel}^{\mathrm{refl}}(A, A)$ of $\mathrm{Rel}(A, A)$ spanned by the reflexive relations.

01RA 2. The **poset of relations on** A is is the subposet $\mathbf{Rel}^{\mathsf{refl}}(A, A)$ of $\mathbf{Rel}(A, A)$ spanned by the reflexive relations.

01RB **Proposition 1.1.1.4.** Let R and S be relations on A.

01RC 1. *Interaction With Inverses.* If R is reflexive, then so is $R^\dagger$.

01RD 2. *Interaction With Composition.* If R and S are reflexive, then so is $S \diamond R$.

Proof. *Item 1, Interaction With Inverses*: Clear.
Item 2, Interaction With Composition: Clear. □

1.2 The Reflexive Closure of a Relation

Let R be a relation on A.

[1] Note that since $\mathbf{Rel}(A, A)$ is posetal, reflexivity is a property of a relation, rather than extra structure.

01RF **Definition 1.2.1.1.** The **reflexive closure** of $\sim_R$ is the relation $\sim_R^{\mathrm{refl}}$[2] satisfying the following universal property:[3]

($\star$) Given another reflexive relation $\sim_S$ on A such that $R \subset S$, there exists an inclusion $\sim_R^{\mathrm{refl}} \subset \sim_S$.

01RG **Construction 1.2.1.2.** Concretely, $\sim_R^{\mathrm{refl}}$ is the free pointed object on R in $(\mathbf{Rel}(A, A), \chi_A)$[4], being given by

$$\begin{aligned} R^{\mathrm{refl}} &\overset{\mathrm{def}}{=} R \coprod^{\mathbf{Rel}(A,A)} \Delta_A \\ &= R \cup \Delta_A \\ &= \{(a, b) \in A \times A \mid \text{we have } a \sim_R b \text{ or } a = b\}. \end{aligned}$$

Proof. Clear. □

01RH **Proposition 1.2.1.3.** Let R be a relation on A.

01RJ 1. *Adjointness.* We have an adjunction

$$\left((-)^{\mathrm{refl}} \dashv \text{忘}\right): \quad \mathbf{Rel}(A, A) \underset{\text{忘}}{\overset{(-)^{\mathrm{refl}}}{\underset{\longleftarrow}{\overset{\longrightarrow}{\perp}}}} \mathbf{Rel}^{\mathsf{refl}}(A, A),$$

witnessed by a bijection of sets

$$\mathbf{Rel}^{\mathsf{refl}}\left(R^{\mathrm{refl}}, S\right) \cong \mathbf{Rel}(R, S),$$

natural in $R \in \mathrm{Obj}\left(\mathbf{Rel}^{\mathsf{refl}}(A, A)\right)$ and $S \in \mathrm{Obj}(\mathbf{Rel}(A, A))$.

01RK 2. *The Reflexive Closure of a Reflexive Relation.* If R is reflexive, then $R^{\mathrm{refl}} = R$.

01RL 3. *Idempotency.* We have

$$\left(R^{\mathrm{refl}}\right)^{\mathrm{refl}} = R^{\mathrm{refl}}.$$

[2] *Further Notation:* Also written R^{refl}.
[3] *Slogan:* The reflexive closure of R is the smallest reflexive relation containing R.
[4] Or, equivalently, the free $\mathbb{E}_0$-monoid on R in $(\mathrm{N}_\bullet(\mathbf{Rel}(A, A)), \chi_A)$.

01RM 4. *Interaction With Inverses.* We have

$$\left(R^{\dagger}\right)^{\mathrm{refl}} = \left(R^{\mathrm{refl}}\right)^{\dagger}, \qquad \begin{tikzcd} \mathrm{Rel}(A,A) \arrow[r, "(-)^{\mathrm{refl}}"] \arrow[d, "(-)^{\dagger}"'] & \mathrm{Rel}(A,A) \arrow[d, "(-)^{\dagger}"] \\ \mathrm{Rel}(A,A) \arrow[r, "(-)^{\mathrm{refl}}"'] & \mathrm{Rel}(A,A). \end{tikzcd}$$

01RN 5. *Interaction With Composition.* We have

$$(S \diamond R)^{\mathrm{refl}} = S^{\mathrm{refl}} \diamond R^{\mathrm{refl}}, \qquad \begin{tikzcd} \mathrm{Rel}(A,A) \times \mathrm{Rel}(A,A) \arrow[r, "\diamond"] \arrow[d, "(-)^{\mathrm{refl}} \times (-)^{\mathrm{refl}}"'] & \mathrm{Rel}(A,A) \arrow[d, "(-)^{\mathrm{refl}}"] \\ \mathrm{Rel}(A,A) \times \mathrm{Rel}(A,A) \arrow[r, "\diamond"'] & \mathrm{Rel}(A,A). \end{tikzcd}$$

Proof. *Item 1, Adjointness*: This is a rephrasing of the universal property of the reflexive closure of a relation, stated in Definition 1.2.1.1.
Item 2, The Reflexive Closure of a Reflexive Relation: Clear.
Item 3, Idempotency: This follows from Item 2.
Item 4, Interaction With Inverses: Clear.
Item 5, Interaction With Composition: This follows from Item 2 of Definition 1.1.1.4. □

2 Symmetric Relations

2.1 Foundations

Let A be a set.

01RR **Definition 2.1.1.1.** A relation R on A is **symmetric** if we have $R^{\dagger} = R$.

01RS **Remark 2.1.1.2.** In detail, a relation R is symmetric if it satisfies the following condition:

($\star$) For each $a, b \in A$, if $a \sim_R b$, then $b \sim_R a$.

01RT **Definition 2.1.1.3.** Let A be a set.

01RU 1. The **set of symmetric relations on** A is the subset $\mathrm{Rel}^{\mathrm{symm}}(A, A)$ of $\mathrm{Rel}(A, A)$ spanned by the symmetric relations.

01RV 2. The **poset of relations on** A is is the subposet $\mathbf{Rel}^{\mathsf{symm}}(A, A)$ of $\mathbf{Rel}(A, A)$ spanned by the symmetric relations.

01RW **Proposition 2.1.1.4.** Let R and S be relations on A.

01RX 1. *Interaction With Inverses.* If R is symmetric, then so is $R^{\dagger}$.

01RY 2. *Interaction With Composition.* If R and S are symmetric, then so is $S \diamond R$.

Proof. *Item 1, Interaction With Inverses*: Clear.
Item 2, Interaction With Composition: Clear. □

2.2 The Symmetric Closure of a Relation

Let R be a relation on A.

01S0 **Definition 2.2.1.1.** The **symmetric closure** of $\sim_R$ is the relation $\sim_R^{\mathrm{symm}}$[5] satisfying the following universal property:[6]

($\star$) Given another symmetric relation $\sim_S$ on A such that $R \subset S$, there exists an inclusion $\sim_R^{\mathrm{symm}} \subset \sim_S$.

01S1 **Construction 2.2.1.2.** Concretely, $\sim_R^{\mathrm{symm}}$ is the symmetric relation on A defined by

$$\begin{aligned} R^{\mathrm{symm}} &\stackrel{\mathrm{def}}{=} R \cup R^{\dagger} \\ &= \{(a, b) \in A \times A \mid \text{we have } a \sim_R b \text{ or } b \sim_R a\}. \end{aligned}$$

Proof. Clear. □

01S2 **Proposition 2.2.1.3.** Let R be a relation on A.

01S3 1. *Adjointness.* We have an adjunction

$$\left((-)^{\mathrm{symm}} \dashv \text{忘}\right) \colon \quad \begin{tikzcd} \mathbf{Rel}(A, A) \arrow[r, bend left, "(-)^{\mathrm{symm}}"] \arrow[r, phantom, "\perp"] & \mathbf{Rel}^{\mathsf{symm}}(A, A), \arrow[l, bend left, "\text{忘}"] \end{tikzcd}$$

[5] *Further Notation:* Also written R^{symm}.
[6] *Slogan:* The symmetric closure of R is the smallest symmetric relation containing R.

witnessed by a bijection of sets

$$\mathbf{Rel}^{\mathsf{symm}}(R^{\mathrm{symm}}, S) \cong \mathbf{Rel}(R, S),$$

natural in $R \in \mathrm{Obj}(\mathbf{Rel}^{\mathsf{symm}}(A, A))$ and $S \in \mathrm{Obj}(\mathbf{Rel}(A, A))$.

01S4 2. *The Symmetric Closure of a Symmetric Relation.* If R is symmetric, then $R^{\mathrm{symm}} = R$.

01S5 3. *Idempotency.* We have

$$(R^{\mathrm{symm}})^{\mathrm{symm}} = R^{\mathrm{symm}}.$$

01S6 4. *Interaction With Inverses.* We have

$$\left(R^{\dagger}\right)^{\mathrm{symm}} = \left(R^{\mathrm{symm}}\right)^{\dagger}, \qquad \begin{tikzcd} \mathrm{Rel}(A, A) \arrow[r, "(-)^{\mathrm{symm}}"] \arrow[d, "(-)^{\dagger}"'] & \mathrm{Rel}(A, A) \arrow[d, "(-)^{\dagger}"] \\ \mathrm{Rel}(A, A) \arrow[r, "(-)^{\mathrm{symm}}"'] & \mathrm{Rel}(A, A). \end{tikzcd}$$

01S7 5. *Interaction With Composition.* We have

$$(S \diamond R)^{\mathrm{symm}} = S^{\mathrm{symm}} \diamond R^{\mathrm{symm}}, \qquad \begin{tikzcd} \mathrm{Rel}(A, A) \times \mathrm{Rel}(A, A) \arrow[r, "\diamond"] \arrow[d, "(-)^{\mathrm{symm}} \times (-)^{\mathrm{symm}}"'] & \mathrm{Rel}(A, A) \arrow[d, "(-)^{\mathrm{symm}}"] \\ \mathrm{Rel}(A, A) \times \mathrm{Rel}(A, A) \arrow[r, "\diamond"'] & \mathrm{Rel}(A, A). \end{tikzcd}$$

Proof. *Item 1*, *Adjointness*: This is a rephrasing of the universal property of the symmetric closure of a relation, stated in Definition 2.2.1.1.
Item 2, *The Symmetric Closure of a Symmetric Relation*: Clear.
Item 3, *Idempotency*: This follows from Item 2.
Item 4, *Interaction With Inverses*: Clear.
Item 5, *Interaction With Composition*: This follows from Item 2 of Definition 2.1.1.4. □

3 Transitive Relations

3.1 Foundations

Let A be a set.

01SA **Definition 3.1.1.1.** A **transitive relation** is equivalently:[7]

- A non-unital $\mathbb{E}_1$-monoid in $(\mathrm{N}_\bullet(\mathbf{Rel}(A, A)), \diamond)$.
- A non-unital monoid in $(\mathbf{Rel}(A, A), \diamond)$.

01SB **Remark 3.1.1.2.** In detail, a relation R on A is **transitive** if we have an inclusion

$$\mu_R \colon R \diamond R \subset R$$

of relations in $\mathbf{Rel}(A, A)$, i.e. if, for each $a, c \in A$, the following condition is satisfied:

($\star$) If there exists some $b \in A$ such that $a \sim_R b$ and $b \sim_R c$, then $a \sim_R c$.

01SC **Definition 3.1.1.3.** Let A be a set.

01SD 1. The **set of transitive relations from A to B** is the subset $\mathrm{Rel}^{\mathrm{trans}}(A)$ of $\mathrm{Rel}(A, A)$ spanned by the transitive relations.

01SE 2. The **poset of relations from A to B** is is the subposet $\mathbf{Rel}^{\mathsf{trans}}(A)$ of $\mathbf{Rel}(A, A)$ spanned by the transitive relations.

01SF **Proposition 3.1.1.4.** Let R and S be relations on A.

01SG 1. *Interaction With Inverses.* If R is transitive, then so is $R^\dagger$.

01SH 2. *Interaction With Composition.* If R and S are transitive, then $S \diamond R$ ***may fail to be transitive***.

Proof. *Item 1, Interaction With Inverses*: Clear.
Item 2, Interaction With Composition: See [MSE 2096272].[8] □

[7] Note that since $\mathbf{Rel}(A, A)$ is posetal, transitivity is a property of a relation, rather than extra structure.

[8] *Intuition:* Transitivity for R and S fails to imply that of $S \diamond R$ because the composition operation for relations intertwines R and S in an incompatible way:

3.2 The Transitive Closure of a Relation

Let R be a relation on A.

01SK **Definition 3.2.1.1.** The **transitive closure** of $\sim_R$ is the relation $\sim_R^{\text{trans}}$[9] satisfying the following universal property:[10]

($\star$) Given another transitive relation $\sim_S$ on A such that $R \subset S$, there exists an inclusion $\sim_R^{\text{trans}} \subset \sim_S$.

01SL **Construction 3.2.1.2.** Concretely, $\sim_R^{\text{trans}}$ is the free non-unital monoid on R in $(\mathbf{Rel}(A, A), \diamond)$[11], being given by

$$\begin{aligned} R^{\text{trans}} &\overset{\text{def}}{=} \coprod_{n=1}^{\infty} R^{\diamond n} \\ &\overset{\text{def}}{=} \bigcup_{n=1}^{\infty} R^{\diamond n} \\ &\overset{\text{def}}{=} \left\{ (a, b) \in A \times B \;\middle|\; \begin{array}{l} \text{there exists some } (x_1, \ldots, x_n) \in R^{\times n} \\ \text{such that } a \sim_R x_1 \sim_R \cdots \sim_R x_n \sim_R b \end{array} \right\}. \end{aligned}$$

Proof. Clear. □

01SM **Proposition 3.2.1.3.** Let R be a relation on A.

01SN 1. *Adjointness.* We have an adjunction

$$\left((-)^{\text{trans}} \dashv \text{忘}\right): \quad \mathbf{Rel}(A, A) \underset{\text{忘}}{\overset{(-)^{\text{trans}}}{\underset{\longleftarrow}{\overset{\longrightarrow}{\bot}}}} \mathbf{Rel}^{\mathsf{trans}}(A, A),$$

- If $a \sim_{S \diamond R} c$ and $c \sim_{S \diamond r} e$, then:
  - There is some $b \in A$ such that:
    - $a \sim_R b$;
    - $b \sim_S c$;
  - There is some $d \in A$ such that:
    - $c \sim_R d$;
    - $d \sim_S e$.

[9] *Further Notation:* Also written R^{trans}.

[10] *Slogan:* The transitive closure of R is the smallest transitive relation containing R.

[11] Or, equivalently, the free non-unital $\mathbb{E}_1$-monoid on R in $(\mathrm{N}_\bullet(\mathbf{Rel}(A, A)), \diamond)$.

witnessed by a bijection of sets

$$\mathbf{Rel}^{\mathsf{trans}}\left(R^{\mathrm{trans}}, S\right) \cong \mathbf{Rel}(R, S),$$

natural in $R \in \mathrm{Obj}\left(\mathbf{Rel}^{\mathsf{trans}}(A, A)\right)$ and $S \in \mathrm{Obj}(\mathbf{Rel}(A, B))$.

01SP 2. *The Transitive Closure of a Transitive Relation.* If R is transitive, then $R^{\mathrm{trans}} = R$.

01SQ 3. *Idempotency.* We have

$$\left(R^{\mathrm{trans}}\right)^{\mathrm{trans}} = R^{\mathrm{trans}}.$$

01SR 4. *Interaction With Inverses.* We have

$$\left(R^{\dagger}\right)^{\mathrm{trans}} = \left(R^{\mathrm{trans}}\right)^{\dagger}, \qquad \begin{tikzcd} \mathrm{Rel}(A, A) \arrow[r, "(-)^{\mathrm{trans}}"] \arrow[d, "(-)^{\dagger}"'] & \mathrm{Rel}(A, A) \arrow[d, "(-)^{\dagger}"] \\ \mathrm{Rel}(A, A) \arrow[r, "(-)^{\mathrm{trans}}"'] & \mathrm{Rel}(A, A). \end{tikzcd}$$

01SS 5. *Interaction With Composition.* We have

$$(S \diamond R)^{\mathrm{trans}} \overset{\text{poss.}}{\neq} S^{\mathrm{trans}} \diamond R^{\mathrm{trans}}, \qquad \begin{tikzcd} \mathrm{Rel}(A, A) \times \mathrm{Rel}(A, A) \arrow[r, "\diamond"] \arrow[d, "(-)^{\mathrm{trans}} \times (-)^{\mathrm{trans}}"'] \arrow[dr, phantom, "\times"] & \mathrm{Rel}(A, A) \arrow[d, "(-)^{\mathrm{trans}}"] \\ \mathrm{Rel}(A, A) \times \mathrm{Rel}(A, A) \arrow[r, "\diamond"'] & \mathrm{Rel}(A, A). \end{tikzcd}$$

Proof. *Item 1*, *Adjointness*: This is a rephrasing of the universal property of the transitive closure of a relation, stated in Definition 3.2.1.1.
Item 2, *The Transitive Closure of a Transitive Relation*: Clear.
Item 3, *Idempotency*: This follows from Item 2.
Item 4, *Interaction With Inverses*: We have

$$\begin{aligned} \left(R^{\dagger}\right)^{\mathrm{trans}} &= \bigcup_{n=1}^{\infty} \left(R^{\dagger}\right)^{\diamond n} \\ &= \bigcup_{n=1}^{\infty} (R^{\diamond n})^{\dagger} \end{aligned}$$

$$= \left(\bigcup_{n=1}^{\infty} R^{\diamond n}\right)^{\dagger}$$
$$= \left(R^{\mathrm{trans}}\right)^{\dagger},$$

where we have used, respectively:

- Definition 3.2.1.2.
- Constructions With Relations, Item 4 of Definition 3.12.1.3.
- Constructions With Relations, Item 1 of Definition 3.6.1.2.
- Definition 3.2.1.2.

This finishes the proof.
Item 5, Interaction With Composition: This follows from Item 2 of Definition 3.1.1.4. □

4 Equivalence Relations

4.1 Foundations

Let A be a set.

01SV **Definition 4.1.1.1.** A relation R is an **equivalence relation** if it is reflexive, symmetric, and transitive.[12]

01SW **Example 4.1.1.2.** The **kernel of a function** $f\colon A \to B$ is the equivalence relation $\sim_{\mathrm{Ker}(f)}$ on A obtained by declaring $a \sim_{\mathrm{Ker}(f)} b$ iff $f(a) = f(b)$.[13]

01SX **Definition 4.1.1.3.** Let A and B be sets.

01SY 1. The **set of equivalence relations from** A **to** B is the subset $\mathrm{Rel}^{\mathrm{eq}}(A, B)$ of $\mathrm{Rel}(A, B)$ spanned by the equivalence relations.

01SZ 2. The **poset of relations from** A **to** B is is the subposet $\mathbf{Rel}^{\mathrm{eq}}(A, B)$ of $\mathbf{Rel}(A, B)$ spanned by the equivalence relations.

[12] *Further Terminology:* If instead R is just symmetric and transitive, then it is called a **partial equivalence relation**.

[13] The kernel $\mathrm{Ker}(f)\colon A \nrightarrow A$ of f is the underlying functor of the monad induced by the adjunction $\mathrm{Gr}(f) \dashv f^{-1}\colon A \rightleftarrows B$ in **Rel** of Constructions With Relations, Item 2 of

4.2 The Equivalence Closure of a Relation

Let R be a relation on A.

01T1 **Definition 4.2.1.1.** The **equivalence closure**[14] of $\sim_R$ is the relation $\sim_R^{\mathrm{eq}}$[15] satisfying the following universal property:[16]

($\star$) Given another equivalence relation $\sim_S$ on A such that $R \subset S$, there exists an inclusion $\sim_R^{\mathrm{eq}} \subset \sim_S$.

01T2 **Construction 4.2.1.2.** Concretely, $\sim_R^{\mathrm{eq}}$ is the equivalence relation on A defined by

$$\begin{aligned} R^{\mathrm{eq}} &\overset{\mathrm{def}}{=} \left(\left(R^{\mathrm{refl}}\right)^{\mathrm{symm}}\right)^{\mathrm{trans}} \\ &= \left(\left(R^{\mathrm{symm}}\right)^{\mathrm{trans}}\right)^{\mathrm{refl}} \\ &= \left\{ (a,b) \in A \times B \;\middle|\; \begin{array}{l} \text{there exists } (x_1, \ldots, x_n) \in R^{\times n} \text{ satisfying at} \\ \text{least one of the following conditions:} \\ \quad 1.\ \text{The following conditions are satisfied:} \\ \quad\quad (a)\ \text{We have } a \sim_R x_1 \text{ or } x_1 \sim_R a; \\ \quad\quad (b)\ \text{We have } x_i \sim_R x_{i+1} \text{ or } x_{i+1} \sim_R x_i \\ \quad\quad\quad \text{for each } 1 \leq i \leq n-1; \\ \quad\quad (c)\ \text{We have } b \sim_R x_n \text{ or } x_n \sim_R b; \\ \quad 2.\ \text{We have } a = b. \end{array} \right\}. \end{aligned}$$

Proof. From the universal properties of the reflexive, symmetric, and transitive closures of a relation (Definitions 1.2.1.1, 2.2.1.1 and 3.2.1.1), we see that it suffices to prove that:

01T3 1. The symmetric closure of a reflexive relation is still reflexive.

01T4 2. The transitive closure of a symmetric relation is still symmetric.

which are both clear. □

01T5 **Proposition 4.2.1.3.** Let R be a relation on A.

Definition 3.1.1.2.

[14] *Further Terminology:* Also called the **equivalence relation associated to** $\sim_R$.

[15] *Further Notation:* Also written R^{eq}.

[16] *Slogan:* The equivalence closure of R is the smallest equivalence relation containing R.

01T6 1. *Adjointness.* We have an adjunction

$$\left((-)^{\mathrm{eq}} \dashv \text{忘}\right): \quad \begin{tikzcd} \mathbf{Rel}(A,B) \arrow[r, bend left, "(-)^{\mathrm{eq}}"] \arrow[r, phantom, "\perp"] & \mathbf{Rel}^{\mathrm{eq}}(A,B), \arrow[l, bend left, "\text{忘}"] \end{tikzcd}$$

witnessed by a bijection of sets

$$\mathbf{Rel}^{\mathrm{eq}}(R^{\mathrm{eq}}, S) \cong \mathbf{Rel}(R, S),$$

natural in $R \in \mathrm{Obj}(\mathbf{Rel}^{\mathrm{eq}}(A,B))$ and $S \in \mathrm{Obj}(\mathbf{Rel}(A,B))$.

01T7 2. *The Equivalence Closure of an Equivalence Relation.* If R is an equivalence relation, then $R^{\mathrm{eq}} = R$.

01T8 3. *Idempotency.* We have

$$(R^{\mathrm{eq}})^{\mathrm{eq}} = R^{\mathrm{eq}}.$$

Proof. *Item 1, Adjointness*: This is a rephrasing of the universal property of the equivalence closure of a relation, stated in Definition 4.2.1.1.
Item 2, The Equivalence Closure of an Equivalence Relation: Clear.
Item 3, Idempotency: This follows from Item 2. □

5 Quotients by Equivalence Relations

5.1 Equivalence Classes

Let A be a set, let R be a relation on A, and let $a \in A$.

01TB **Definition 5.1.1.1.** The **equivalence class associated to** a is the set $[a]$ defined by

$$\begin{aligned} [a] &\overset{\mathrm{def}}{=} \{x \in X \mid x \sim_R a\} \\ &= \{x \in X \mid a \sim_R x\}. && \text{(since } R \text{ is symmetric)} \end{aligned}$$

5.2 Quotients of Sets by Equivalence Relations

Let A be a set and let R be a relation on A.

01TD **Definition 5.2.1.1.** The **quotient of** X **by** R is the set $X/{\sim_R}$ defined by

$$X/{\sim_R} \stackrel{\text{def}}{=} \{[a] \in \mathcal{P}(X) \mid a \in X\}.$$

01TE **Remark 5.2.1.2.** The reason we define quotient sets for equivalence relations only is that each of the properties of being an equivalence relation—reflexivity, symmetry, and transitivity—ensures that the equivalences classes $[a]$ of X under R are well-behaved:

- *Reflexivity.* If R is reflexive, then, for each $a \in X$, we have $a \in [a]$.
- *Symmetry.* The equivalence class $[a]$ of an element a of X is defined by

  $$[a] \stackrel{\text{def}}{=} \{x \in X \mid x \sim_R a\},$$

  but we could equally well define

  $$[a]' \stackrel{\text{def}}{=} \{x \in X \mid a \sim_R x\}$$

  instead. This is not a problem when R is symmetric, as we then have $[a] = [a]'$.[17]
- *Transitivity.* If R is transitive, then $[a]$ and $[b]$ are disjoint iff $a \nsim_R b$, and equal otherwise.

01TF **Proposition 5.2.1.3.** Let $f\colon X \to Y$ be a function and let R be a relation on X.

01TG 1. *As a Coequaliser.* We have an isomorphism of sets

$$X/{\sim_R^{\text{eq}}} \cong \operatorname{CoEq}\left(R \hookrightarrow X \times X \underset{\text{pr}_2}{\overset{\text{pr}_1}{\rightrightarrows}} X\right),$$

where $\sim_R^{\text{eq}}$ is the equivalence relation generated by $\sim_R$.

[17] When categorifying equivalence relations, one finds that $[a]$ and $[a]'$ correspond to presheaves and copresheaves; see Constructions With Categories, **??**.

01TH 2. *As a Pushout.* We have an isomorphism of sets[18]

$$X/{\sim}_R^{\mathrm{eq}} \cong X \coprod_{\mathrm{Eq}(\mathrm{pr}_1,\mathrm{pr}_2)} X, \qquad \begin{tikzcd} X/{\sim}_R^{\mathrm{eq}} \arrow[dr, phantom, "\ulcorner", very near start] & X \arrow[l] \\ X \arrow[u] & \mathrm{Eq}(\mathrm{pr}_1, \mathrm{pr}_2). \arrow[l] \arrow[u] \end{tikzcd}$$

where ${\sim}_R^{\mathrm{eq}}$ is the equivalence relation generated by ${\sim}_R$.

01TJ 3. *The First Isomorphism Theorem for Sets.* We have an isomorphism of sets[19,20]

$$X/{\sim}_{\mathrm{Ker}(f)} \cong \mathrm{Im}(f).$$

01TK 4. *Descending Functions to Quotient Sets, I.* Let R be an equivalence relation on X. The following conditions are equivalent:

027L (a) There exists a map

$$\bar{f}\colon X/{\sim}_R \to Y$$

[18]Dually, we also have an isomorphism of sets

$$\mathrm{Eq}(\mathrm{pr}_1, \mathrm{pr}_2) \cong X \times_{X/{\sim}_R^{\mathrm{eq}}} X, \qquad \begin{tikzcd} \mathrm{Eq}(\mathrm{pr}_1, \mathrm{pr}_2) \arrow[r] \arrow[d] \arrow[dr, phantom, "\lrcorner", very near start] & X \arrow[d] \\ X \arrow[r] & X/{\sim}_R^{\mathrm{eq}}. \end{tikzcd}$$

[19]*Further Terminology:* The set $X/{\sim}_{\mathrm{Ker}(f)}$ is often called the **coimage of** f, and denoted by $\mathrm{CoIm}(f)$.

[20]In a sense this is a result relating the monad in **Rel** induced by f with the comonad in **Rel** induced by f, as the kernel and image

$$\mathrm{Ker}(f)\colon X \nrightarrow X,$$
$$\mathrm{Im}(f) \subset Y$$

of f are the underlying functors of (respectively) the induced monad and comonad of the adjunction

$$\big(\mathrm{Gr}(f) \dashv f^{-1}\big)\colon \quad \begin{tikzcd} A \arrow[r, bend left, "\mathrm{Gr}(f)"] \arrow[r, phantom, "\perp"] & B \arrow[l, bend left, "f^{-1}"] \end{tikzcd}$$

of Constructions With Relations, Item 2 of Definition 3.1.1.2.

making the diagram

$$\begin{tikzcd} X \arrow[r, "f"] \arrow[d, two heads, "q"'] & Y \\ X/{\sim_R} \arrow[ur, dotted, "\exists\ \bar{f}"'] & \end{tikzcd}$$

commute.

027M (b) We have $R \subset \mathrm{Ker}(f)$.

027N (c) For each $x, y \in X$, if $x \sim_R y$, then $f(x) = f(y)$.

01TL 5. *Descending Functions to Quotient Sets, II.* Let R be an equivalence relation on X. If the conditions of Item 4 hold, then $\bar{f}$ is the *unique* map making the diagram

$$\begin{tikzcd} X \arrow[r, "f"] \arrow[d, two heads, "q"'] & Y \\ X/{\sim_R} \arrow[ur, dashed, "\exists!\ \bar{f}"'] & \end{tikzcd}$$

commute.

01TM 6. *Descending Functions to Quotient Sets, III.* Let R be an equivalence relation on X. We have a bijection

$$\mathrm{Hom}_{\mathsf{Sets}}(X/{\sim_R}, Y) \cong \mathrm{Hom}^R_{\mathsf{Sets}}(X, Y),$$

natural in $X, Y \in \mathrm{Obj}(\mathsf{Sets})$, given by the assignment $f \mapsto \bar{f}$ of Items 4 and 5, where $\mathrm{Hom}^R_{\mathsf{Sets}}(X, Y)$ is the set defined by

$$\mathrm{Hom}^R_{\mathsf{Sets}}(X, Y) \stackrel{\text{def}}{=} \left\{ f \in \mathrm{Hom}_{\mathsf{Sets}}(X, Y) \;\middle|\; \begin{array}{l} \text{for each } x, y \in X, \\ \text{if } x \sim_R y, \text{ then} \\ f(x) = f(y) \end{array} \right\}.$$

01TN 7. *Descending Functions to Quotient Sets, IV.* Let R be an equivalence relation on X. If the conditions of Item 4 hold, then the following conditions are equivalent:

027P (a) The map $\bar{f}$ is an injection.

027Q (b) We have $R = \mathrm{Ker}(f)$.

027R (c) For each $x, y \in X$, we have $x \sim_R y$ iff $f(x) = f(y)$.

01TP 8. *Descending Functions to Quotient Sets, V.* Let R be an equivalence relation on X. If the conditions of Item 4 hold, then the following conditions are equivalent:

01TR (a) The map $f\colon X \to Y$ is surjective.

01TS (b) The map $\bar{f}\colon X/{\sim_R} \to Y$ is surjective.

01TQ 9. *Descending Functions to Quotient Sets, VI.* Let R be a relation on X and let $\sim_R^{\mathrm{eq}}$ be the equivalence relation associated to R. The following conditions are equivalent:

027S (a) The map f satisfies the equivalent conditions of Item 4:

- There exists a map

$$\bar{f}\colon X/{\sim_R^{\mathrm{eq}}} \to Y$$

making the diagram

$$\begin{tikzcd} X \arrow[r, "f"] \arrow[d, two heads, "q"'] & Y \\ X/{\sim_R^{\mathrm{eq}}} \arrow[ur, dotted, "\exists\ \bar{f}"'] & \end{tikzcd}$$

commute.

- For each $x, y \in X$, if $x \sim_R^{\mathrm{eq}} y$, then $f(x) = f(y)$.

027T (b) For each $x, y \in X$, if $x \sim_R y$, then $f(x) = f(y)$.

Proof. *Item 1, As a Coequaliser*: Omitted.
Item 2, As a Pushout: Omitted.
Item 3, The First Isomorphism Theorem for Sets: Clear.
Item 4, Descending Functions to Quotient Sets, I: See [Pro24c].
Item 5, Descending Functions to Quotient Sets, II: See [Pro24d].
Item 6, Descending Functions to Quotient Sets, III: This follows from Items 5 and 6.
Item 7, Descending Functions to Quotient Sets, IV: See [Pro24b].

Item 8, Descending Functions to Quotient Sets, V: See [Pro24a].
Item 9, Descending Functions to Quotient Sets, VI: The implication Item 8a $\Longrightarrow$ Item 8b is clear.

Conversely, suppose that, for each $x, y \in X$, if $x \sim_R y$, then $f(x) = f(y)$. Spelling out the definition of the equivalence closure of R, we see that the condition $x \sim_R^{\text{eq}} y$ unwinds to the following:

($\star$) There exist $(x_1, \ldots, x_n) \in R^{\times n}$ satisfying at least one of the following conditions:

- The following conditions are satisfied:
  - We have $x \sim_R x_1$ or $x_1 \sim_R x$;
  - We have $x_i \sim_R x_{i+1}$ or $x_{i+1} \sim_R x_i$ for each $1 \leq i \leq n-1$;
  - We have $y \sim_R x_n$ or $x_n \sim_R y$;
- We have $x = y$.

Now, if $x = y$, then $f(x) = f(y)$ trivially; otherwise, we have

$$\begin{aligned} f(x) &= f(x_1), \\ f(x_1) &= f(x_2), \\ &\vdots \\ f(x_{n-1}) &= f(x_n), \\ f(x_n) &= f(y), \end{aligned}$$

and $f(x) = f(y)$, as we wanted to show. $\square$

Appendices

A Other Chapters

Sets

1. Sets
2. Constructions With Sets
3. Monoidal Structures on the Category of Sets
4. Pointed Sets
5. Tensor Products of Pointed Sets

Relations

6. Relations
7. Constructions With Relations
8. Equivalence Relations and Apartness Relations

Category Theory

9. Categories

Monoidal Categories

10. Constructions With Monoidal Categories

Bicategories

11. Types of Morphisms in Bicategories

References

[MSE 2096272] Akiva Weinberger. *Is composition of two transitive relations transitive? If not, can you give me a counterexample?* Mathematics Stack Exchange. URL: https://math.stackexchange.com/q/2096272 (cit. on p. 7).

[Pro24a] Proof Wiki Contributors. *Condition For Mapping from Quotient Set To Be A Surjection — Proof Wiki*. 2024. URL: https://proofwiki.org/wiki/Condition_for_Mapping_from_Quotient_Set_to_be_Surjection (cit. on p. 17).

[Pro24b] Proof Wiki Contributors. *Condition For Mapping From Quotient Set To Be An Injection— Proof Wiki*. 2024. URL: https://proofwiki.org/wiki/Condition_for_Mapping_from_Quotient_Set_to_be_Injection (cit. on p. 16).

[Pro24c] Proof Wiki Contributors. *Condition For Mapping From Quotient Set To Be Well-Defined — Proof Wiki*. 2024. URL: https://proofwiki.org/wiki/Condition_for_Mapping_from_Quotient_Set_to_be_Well-Defined (cit. on p. 16).

[Pro24d] Proof Wiki Contributors. *Mapping From Quotient Set When Defined Is Unique — Proof Wiki*. 2024. URL: https://proofwiki.org/wiki/Mapping_from_Quotient_Set_when_Defined_is_Unique (cit. on p. 16).